

the same frugal lifestyle, waiting for the day when their hardship would pay off. For Quinton, it took three years.

Quinton sold his first screenplay for what seemed like a fortune to him. He promptly moved from his cheap studio apartment into an upscale place in a high-rent neighborhood. He traded in his old car for a brand new luxury model. He dined in expensive restaurants every night and treated his friends. And of course, he quit his job waiting tables.

This new rich lifestyle that Quinton adopted soon became addictive. Quinton loved being able to spend money without first analyzing his budget to see if he could afford it. The money he received from his screenplay was equal to what most of his friends took years at a steady job to earn. Because Quinton had stopped living on a budget, he managed to spend it all in just a year. It is amazing how fast money goes when you spend it with abandon.

After the money was gone, Quinton was in denial about the fact that he was broke. He enjoyed his lavish lifestyle and was not about to give it up. He rationalized to himself that he deserved it after having to live on such a meager income for so long. Unfortunately, continuous spending without an income to offset it always comes to an end. When Quinton's credit ran out, he was \$90,000 in debt.

He completed work on his new screenplay, but soon discovered that he couldn't sell it because no one liked it. With no foreseeable income stream, Quinton had no means to pay his outstanding credit card debts. He decided the only way out was to file for bankruptcy.

All too often, people panic and do not realize there are other alternatives. The reduction of your debt payments is sometimes the answer. You can try negotiating on your own with the creditors to work out a more manageable payment plan. Start by sending them a proposal package. This package

